BONUS 1: The WeddingForge Google Sheets Budget Tracker

Fully Formula-Driven — No Math Required

Overview

This tracker replaces every wedding app budget tool on the market. Here is why: wedding apps give you pretty pie charts but obscure the actual numbers. This spreadsheet puts every dollar on one screen, tells you exactly what you owe and when, and never lets you accidentally double-book a payment.

What this tracker does:

- Tracks every budget line item from first quote to final payment
- Calculates your remaining budget in real time
- Sends visual warnings when payment deadlines are approaching
- Manages your full guest list and meal counts
- Stores every vendor contact in one place

Setup time: 90 minutes to build from scratch, 5 minutes per week to maintain.

Requirements: A free Google account. Go to sheets.google.com and create a new blank spreadsheet. Name it `WeddingForge Budget — [Your Names] [Wedding Year]`.

Sheet Architecture

Create five tabs at the bottom of your spreadsheet. Right-click the default "Sheet1" tab to rename it, then click the "+" icon to add the remaining tabs.

TAB #	TAB NAME	PURPOSE
1	DASHBOARD	High-level financial summary and key stats
2	BUDGET	Full line-item budget with vendor and status tracking
3	PAYMENTS	Payment schedule with deadline alerts
4	VENDORS	Vendor contact directory
5	RSVP	Guest list, meal choices, gifts, and thank-you tracking

Tab 1: DASHBOARD Setup

The DASHBOARD is your command center. Every number here pulls automatically from the other tabs. You will never manually type a dollar amount on this page.

STEP 1: SET UP THE HEADER

In cell **A1**, type your wedding title: `[Partner A] & [Partner B] — Wedding Budget Dashboard`
In cell **A2**, type your wedding date in this exact format: `2026-10-03` (adjust to your actual date)

Apply bold formatting to A1. Make font size 18. Make A2 font size 12, color gray.

STEP 2: BUILD THE SUMMARY TABLE

Set up the following cells. Column A contains the label, Column B contains the value or formula. Make Column A bold.

CELL	LABEL (COLUMN A)	FORMULA OR INPUT (COLUMN B)
A5	Total Budget	**Manual input** — type your total budget number here, e.g. `45000`
A6	Total Committed	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!E:E,"Contracted",BUDGET!D:D)`
A7	Total Paid	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!E:E,"Paid",BUDGET!D:D)`
A8	Total Remaining Budget	`=B5-B6`
A9	Contingency Reserve (10%)	`=B5*0.10`
A10	Available to Spend	`=B5-B9-B6`
A11	Guest Count	**Manual input** — type your expected guest count
A12	Cost Per Head	`=IFERROR(B6/B11,"Enter guest count")`
A13	Days Until Wedding	`=IFERROR(DATEDIF(TODAY(),A2,"D"),"Check wedding date")`

Format Column B as currency (Format > Number > Currency) for rows 5 through 10 and row 12. Leave B13 as a plain number.

STEP 3: CONDITIONAL FORMATTING ALERT

If your Available to Spend (B10) goes negative, you need an immediate visual warning.

1. Click cell **B10**
2. Go to Format > Conditional formatting
3. Under "Format cells if," select "Less than"
4. Enter `0` in the value field
5. Set the formatting style: Background color = Red, Text color = White, Bold = On
6. Click Done

Add a second rule on the same cell: if B10 is greater than or equal to 0, set background to light green. This gives you a green/red signal at a glance.

STEP 4: FORMAT FOR READABILITY

- Merge and center A1 across A1:B1

- Set row heights to 28 for rows 5 through 13
- Add a thick border around the range A5:B13
- Add alternating row colors (light gray, white) using Format > Alternating colors

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Tab 2: BUDGET Setup

This is the heart of the tracker. Every vendor quote, contract, and payment lives here.

COLUMN HEADERS

Click row 1 and set up the following headers. Bold all of them. Freeze row 1 (View > Freeze > 1 row).

COL	HEADER	FORMAT
A	Category	Text
B	Item	Text
C	Vendor Name	Text
D	Amount	Currency
E	Status	Dropdown
F	Deposit Paid	Currency
G	Balance Due	Currency
H	Due Date	Date
I	Notes	Text

SETTING UP THE STATUS DROPDOWN (COLUMN E)

1. Select the entire Column E (click the E header)
2. Go to Data > Data validation
3. Under Criteria, select "Dropdown (from a list)"
4. Enter these exact options: `Research, Quoted, Contracted, Paid`
5. Click Save

COLUMN G FORMULA

Column G (Balance Due) should auto-calculate. In G2, enter this formula and copy it down all rows:

```
=IF(D2="","",D2-F2)
```

This calculates the remaining balance for each line item automatically.

FULL LINE-ITEM LIST

Enter every row below. For each **Category Subtotal row**, merge cells A and B, bold the text, and shade the row light blue.

VENUE & CEREMONY

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
3	Venue & Ceremony	Ceremony venue rental fee
4	Venue & Ceremony	Reception venue rental fee
5	Venue & Ceremony	Venue coordinator day-of fee
6	Venue & Ceremony	Ceremony sound system / AV rental
7	Venue & Ceremony	Officiant fee
8	Venue & Ceremony	Marriage license fee
9	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Venue & Ceremony",D:D)`

CATERING & BAR

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
11	Catering & Bar	Catering per-head cost
12	Catering & Bar	Bar package / open bar
13	Catering & Bar	Wedding cake / dessert bar
14	Catering & Bar	Cocktail hour appetizers
15	Catering & Bar	Late-night snack station
16	Catering & Bar	Cake cutting fee (if venue charges)
17	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Catering & Bar",D:D)`

PHOTOGRAPHY & VIDEO

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
19	Photography & Video	Lead photographer package
20	Photography & Video	Second shooter
21	Photography & Video	Videography package
22	Photography & Video	Photo booth rental
23	Photography & Video	Engagement session
24	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Photography & Video",D:D)`

FLORALS & DECOR

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
26	Florals & Decor	Bridal bouquet
27	Florals & Decor	Bridesmaids bouquets
28	Florals & Decor	Boutonnieres
29	Florals & Decor	Ceremony arch / altar arrangement
30	Florals & Decor	Ceremony aisle flowers
31	Florals & Decor	Cocktail hour centerpieces
32	Florals & Decor	Reception table centerpieces
33	Florals & Decor	Cake florals
34	Florals & Decor	Miscellaneous petals / loose florals
35	Florals & Decor	Candles and non-floral decor rentals
36	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Florals & Decor",D:D)`

MUSIC

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
38	Music	DJ package
39	Music	Live band (ceremony or cocktail hour)
40	Music	Ceremony musician (violinist, guitarist, etc.)
41	Music	Sound system rental (if not included with venue)
42	Music	MC services
43	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Music",D:D)`

ATTIRE

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
45	Attire	Wedding dress
46	Attire	Dress alterations
47	Attire	Veil and accessories
48	Attire	Partner 2 suit / tux / outfit
49	Attire	Partner 2 alterations
50	Attire	Bridesmaid dresses (if couple is paying)
51	Attire	Groomsmen attire (if couple is paying)
52	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Attire",D:D)`

BEAUTY

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
54	Beauty	Bridal hair styling
55	Beauty	Bridal makeup
56	Beauty	Trial hair and makeup session
57	Beauty	Bridesmaids hair (if couple is paying)
58	Beauty	Bridesmaids makeup (if couple is paying)
59	Beauty	Pre-wedding skincare / spa treatments
60	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Beauty",D:D)`

PAPER & STATIONERY

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
62	Paper & Stationery	Save-the-dates (design + print)
63	Paper & Stationery	Invitations (design + print)
64	Paper & Stationery	Invitation postage (inner + outer)
65	Paper & Stationery	RSVP card postage
66	Paper & Stationery	Ceremony programs
67	Paper & Stationery	Escort cards / place cards
68	Paper & Stationery	Menus
69	Paper & Stationery	Thank-you cards + postage
70	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Paper & Stationery",D:D)`

LOGISTICS

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
72	Logistics	Guest shuttle / transportation
73	Logistics	Wedding party transportation (limo, sprinter)
74	Logistics	Couple's getaway car
75	Logistics	Parking fees or valet
76	Logistics	Wedding night hotel room
77	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Logistics",D:D)`

HOSPITALITY

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
79	Hospitality	Welcome bags (materials + assembly)
80	Hospitality	Hotel room block coordination gift
81	Hospitality	Rehearsal dinner (if couple is hosting)
82	Hospitality	Day-after brunch (if couple is hosting)
83	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Hospitality",D:D)`

TIPS & GRATUITY

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
85	Tips & Gratuity	Photographer tip
86	Tips & Gratuity	Videographer tip
87	Tips & Gratuity	DJ / band tip
88	Tips & Gratuity	Catering staff / captain tip
89	Tips & Gratuity	Hair and makeup tip
90	Tips & Gratuity	Florist tip
91	Tips & Gratuity	Officiant honorarium
92	Tips & Gratuity	Transportation driver tips
93	Tips & Gratuity	Venue coordinator tip
94	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Tips & Gratuity",D:D)`

CONTINGENCY

ROW	A: CATEGORY	B: ITEM
96	Contingency	Emergency / overflow fund
97	**SUBTOTAL**	`=SUMIF(A:A,"Contingency",D:D)`

GRAND TOTAL ROW

In row 99, add:

CELL	CONTENT
A99	**GRAND TOTAL** (bold, large font)
D99	`=B9+B17+B24+B36+B43+B52+B60+B70+B77+B83+B94+B97`

Alternatively, use this cleaner version that sums all subtotal cells:

```
=SUM(B9,B17,B24,B36,B43,B52,B60,B70,B77,B83,B94,B97)
```

CATEGORY BUDGET VS. ACTUAL COMPARISON

To the right of your main table (starting in Column K), set up this comparison table. Manually enter your budgeted amount for each category in Column L. Column M auto-calculates actuals.

COL K	COL L	COL M	COL N
Category	Budgeted	Actual Contracted	Variance
Venue & Ceremony	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Venue & Ceremony",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L2-M2`
Catering & Bar	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Catering & Bar",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L3-M3`
Photography & Video	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Photography & Video",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L4-M4`
Florals & Decor	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Florals & Decor",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L5-M5`
Music	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Music",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L6-M6`
Attire	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Attire",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L7-M7`
Beauty	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Beauty",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L8-M8`
Paper & Stationery	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Paper & Stationery",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L9-M9`
Logistics	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Logistics",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L10-M10`
Hospitality	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Hospitality",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L11-M11`
Tips & Gratuity	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Tips & Gratuity",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L12-M12`
Contingency	[manual input]	`=SUMIF(BUDGET!A:A,"Contingency",BUDGET!D:D)`	`=L13-M13`

Apply conditional formatting to Column N: negative values (over budget) = red, positive values (under budget) = green.

Tab 3: PAYMENTS Setup

The PAYMENTS tab is your payment deadline calendar. It answers the question: "What do I owe, to whom, and when?"

COLUMN HEADERS

Freeze row 1. Set up these columns:

COL	HEADER	FORMAT
A	Vendor	Text
B	Category	Text
C	Total Contract Amount	Currency
D	Deposit Amount	Currency
E	Deposit Due Date	Date
F	Deposit Paid	Checkbox
G	Balance Amount	Currency
H	Balance Due Date	Date
I	Balance Paid	Checkbox
J	Notes	Text

AUTO-CALCULATE BALANCE AMOUNT

In column G, enter this formula for each row (starting at G2):

```
=C2-D2
```

This calculates the balance automatically once you enter the contract total and deposit amount.

CONDITIONAL FORMATTING: DEADLINE ALERT

This rule highlights any upcoming payment you have not yet made.

For Deposit Due Dates (Column E):

1. Select Column E (E2:E100)
2. Format > Conditional formatting
3. Add rule: Custom formula is: `=AND(E2-TODAY()<=14, E2-TODAY()>=0, F2=FALSE)`
4. Formatting: Background = Orange, Text = Black, Bold = On
5. Label this rule "Deposit due in 14 days — unpaid"

For Balance Due Dates (Column H):

1. Select Column H (H2:H100)
2. Repeat the same process with formula: `=AND(H2-TODAY()<=14, H2-TODAY()>=0, I2=FALSE)`
3. Same orange formatting

Add a second rule for overdue payments: `=AND(E2<TODAY(), F2=FALSE)` with red background — this catches anything past-due.

TOTAL OUTSTANDING FORMULA

At the bottom of your PAYMENTS tab (e.g., row 102), add this summary:

CELL	LABEL	FORMULA
A102	Total Deposits Outstanding	`=SUMIF(F2:F100,FALSE,D2:D100)`
A103	Total Balances Outstanding	`=SUMIF(I2:I100,FALSE,G2:G100)`
A104	**Total Outstanding — All**	`=A102+A103`

Format A104 in bold with a thick top border.

SORTING TIP

Once your data is entered, click any cell in Column E and use Data > Sort sheet by column E (A to Z). This puts your most imminent deposit deadline at the top.

Tab 4: VENDORS Setup

The VENDORS tab is your vendor rolodex. Every person you hired lives here.

COLUMN HEADERS

COL	HEADER	FORMAT
A	Category	Dropdown
B	Vendor Name	Text
C	Contact Name	Text
D	Phone	Text
E	Email	Text
F	Contract Signed	Checkbox
G	Arrival Time	Time
H	Notes	Text

Set up Column A as a dropdown (Data > Data validation) with these options: `Venue, Photography, Videography, Catering, Bar, Florals, Music/DJ, Beauty, Officiant, Transportation, Stationery, Rentals, Other`

VENDOR STATUS SUMMARY

Below your vendor list (e.g., starting at row 30), add this summary block:

CELL	LABEL	FORMULA
A30	Total Vendors	`=COUNTA(B2:B29)`
A31	Contracts Signed	`=COUNTIF(F2:F29,TRUE)`
A32	Contracts NOT Signed	`=COUNTIF(F2:F29,FALSE)`
A33	% Contracted	`=IFERROR(A31/A30,"0%")` (format as %)

Apply conditional formatting to A32: if value is greater than 0, highlight yellow. This reminds you that unsigned contracts are outstanding.

Tab 5: RSVP Setup

The RSVP tab manages your guest list from invitation to thank-you note.

COLUMN HEADERS

COL	HEADER	FORMAT
A	Last Name	Text
B	First Name(s)	Text
C	Side	Dropdown
D	Invited	Checkbox
E	RSVP Status	Dropdown
F	Meal Choice	Dropdown
G	Dietary Notes	Text
H	Table #	Number
I	Gift Received	Checkbox
J	Thank You Sent	Checkbox

Column C Dropdown options: `Bride/Groom/Both` **Column E Dropdown options:** `Pending/Attending/Not Attending` **Column F Dropdown options:** `Chicken/Fish/Vegetarian/Kids Menu/No Preference`

SUMMARY FORMULAS

Place these formulas below your guest list (e.g., starting at row 202):

CELL	LABEL	FORMULA
A202	Total Invited	`=COUNTIF(D2:D200,TRUE)`
A203	Total Attending	`=COUNTIF(E2:E200,"Attending")`
A204	Total Not Attending	`=COUNTIF(E2:E200,"Not Attending")`
A205	Still Pending	`=COUNTIF(E2:E200,"Pending")`
A206	Chicken Meals	`=COUNTIFS(E2:E200,"Attending",F2:F200,"Chicken")`
A207	Fish Meals	`=COUNTIFS(E2:E200,"Attending",F2:F200,"Fish")`
A208	Vegetarian Meals	`=COUNTIFS(E2:E200,"Attending",F2:F200,"Vegetarian")`
A209	Kids Meals	`=COUNTIFS(E2:E200,"Attending",F2:F200,"Kids Menu")`
A210	Thank-You Notes Remaining	`=COUNTIFS(I2:I200,TRUE,J2:J200,FALSE)`

The last formula (A210) tells you exactly how many gifts have been received but not yet thanked. Run this weekly after the wedding until it reads zero.

CONDITIONAL FORMATTING: THANK-YOU TRACKER

Select column J (Thank You Sent). Add this rule:

- Custom formula: `=AND(I2=TRUE, J2=FALSE)`
- Formatting: Background = Yellow

This highlights any row where a gift was received but the thank-you has not gone out.

Pro Tips

SHARING WITH YOUR PARTNER

1. In the top-right corner of Google Sheets, click **Share**
2. Enter your partner's email address
3. Set permission to **Editor** so they can update their own assigned vendors and tasks

4. Check "Notify people" so they receive the link immediately

Both of you can edit simultaneously. Google Sheets shows a colored cursor for each person in real time.

PROTECTING FORMULA CELLS

You do not want anyone accidentally overwriting a formula.

1. Select all formula cells (hold Cmd/Ctrl and click each one)
2. Go to Data > Protect sheets and ranges
3. Click "Add a sheet or range"
4. Under "Except certain cells," you can allow editing of input cells only (like Column D on BUDGET)
5. Set a warning or restrict editing to only yourself

ADDING DATA VALIDATION FOR DROPDOWNS

For any column where you want a controlled list:

1. Select the column
2. Data > Data validation
3. Choose "Dropdown (from a list)"
4. Type your options separated by commas
5. Check "Show a dropdown list in the cell"
6. Under "If the data is invalid," select "Show a warning" (not "Reject input" — this allows you to add notes if needed)

EXPORTING TO PDF FOR YOUR COORDINATOR

Your day-of coordinator needs the vendor contact list and timeline on day-of.

1. On the VENDORS tab, go to File > Download > PDF Document
2. Under "Print," select "Current sheet" (not whole workbook)
3. Set orientation to Landscape for wide tables
4. Check "Fit to page width"
5. Click Export

Send this PDF to your coordinator 48 hours before the wedding so they have it even if their phone dies.

--- END OF BONUS 1 ---